

Week 11: Video Transcript

Hello and welcome to our 11th session. This is very exciting. You've made it! Yes! We're almost there. We get to spend the 11th week of this process discussing my very favorite part about being a human and my very favorite part about being a parent, and this is play and storytelling. For some of you play may come naturally. It may be an easy part in your parenting where boundaries, communication, emotional regulation, being aware of what beliefs and thoughts that you have, and how to consciously choose what you're believing and perceiving at any one moment, those may need some work. Me too. Play comes as a relief. For some of you, play may feel like the opposite of what I'm describing. And it may feel, for many parents, I hear it is like nails against a chalkboard. You may find yourself in the continuum where play sometimes comes naturally for you. It's effortless, you're able to find that lighthearted awe and wonder. You can enter your child's world, get down on the floor, really connect in their magic. And sometimes it's more difficult, especially in times of stress and overwhelm, illness, or times of big transition. I'm recording this during the pandemic, so play is a challenge for a lot of parents right now because the stress is so high. But even in normal times, I guess we say now, even in normal times, play can feel very challenging and I want this to be okay for us.

I want us to enter this conversation with an expansive belief that if you struggle playing with your child or children, there isn't something wrong with you. You're not broken. You're not a bad parent. You're not boring. Those things aren't true, and we are here to understand what keeps us blocked from accessing our playfulness from accessing our joy, presence, surrender, awe, wonder, lightheartedness, and sense of humor. All of these qualities and experiences happen when we feel safe inside of our bodies. So we're going to learn the difference between a sympathetic state of play, which we learned last time and with anger and aggression, when we have a sympathetic response, it's our fight or flight response. And when we have that in conjunction with safety, so anger and aggression is when we're not feeling safe, we're perceiving danger, so we're going into fight or flight or having an aggression response. Play is when we feel safe in our body and we are activated in our sympathetic nervous system. So for parents who have been living in the sympathetic nervous system for a long time, survival state, survival stress, you don't know maybe what it feels like to feel safe and have the sympathetic nervous system engaged at the same time.



So this could be a parent where it's impossible for you to slow down. Your child's wanting you to come and get on the floor with them and play fairies and your skin feels like you're gonna fall out of it, and there's bugs crawling all over you, and then suddenly everything that you have to do on your list of a bazillion things is raging in the back of your mind, and you start to hyperventilate and you can't play. I know that feeling and those of you who have lived a long time in the dorsal vagal response, which is the faint and freeze, it's living in chronic stress. But anger, aggression, fighting, and showing up every day didn't help you so you've sunk down into a state of helplessness, despair, powerlessness, depression, catatonic state, which all of us enter at some times. But some of you may live in this place more than others. How do we quantify it? But you will know what I'm speaking of if you live this. It can feel exhausting for you to muster the energy to play, it may feel like you're moving through molasses and seeing your children zip around the place and have all of this exuberance and all of this laughter, it may feel incredibly overwhelming for you and even viscerally painful. So I've described two areas that you may visit at moments, and we're not wanting to make these bad or wrong. We're wanting to be aware of them when they're happening, and to be aware of what safety in our body feels like and joy, wonder, and awe, and then practice having more of those experiences.

So there will be times when your child is saying "Mommy, daddy, play with me!" And your initial response is, "I have a million things to do", or your initial response may be like, "Oh my gosh, I'm so tired. I do not want to play with you." And just being aware that that's happening, "Oh, I'm having this response to play. I'm having an anxious sympathetic response. Oh, I'm having a dorsal vagal avoidant attachment response", because those are normal things to say out loud. And I say them out loud, "Sorry, I can't play right now, honey. I'm having a dorsal vagal avoidant attachment response to your play invitation", which is just funny. It can be funny for you to say that out loud.

So the entire intention behind playful parenting storytelling in your parenting, isn't being a wild baboon and jumping off the walls and being able to keep up with your child necessarily. It's about being able to emanate and radiate a light heart. It is about being in this state of, what an incredible miracle it is to be alive. Like a little child who's looking at the blade of grass for the first time or seeing a bird in the air for the first time. What if we were looking at life like this? What if every scenario that we had was infused with curiosity and that generous assumption that we've talked about, it's infused with a longing to immerse yourself into it and understand. So this is the social engagement, ventral vagal response that we've talked about in the week on the nervous system.



And don't worry if you don't remember anything you learned from that week, just go ahead and go back to week five and listen to the video again, it's going to take time for it to sink into you and for you to remember it. It's all good. Living in the social engagement system is living in a secure attachment within our own selves. It is living with safety inside of our heart, brain, and body. It is from this place that we access authentic joy. Authentic joy isn't the fighting and flailing around, being on fire, and being exuberant. It's actually being in a state of incredible stillness on the inside. So even if you're being playful and rambunctious, there's a stillness, there's a presence. You're not losing yourself to the play, you're coming home. You're so embodied and present. It brings tears to your eyes, how beautiful the moment is and how you see the spark of magic. And for parents listening to this and thinking, "What?" I think that's okay for you. Working with a coach is about being able to remember and reclaim this part of you because we were all born with it. This is the birthright, and I believe, the natural state of being for humanity. But we've been in a prolonged stress cycle for generations because of the way we've been parenting and parented. And of course there's cultural, historical, racial, health, all kinds of environmental injustice. There's all kinds of factors that impact the stress level in your lineage and how it's impacted you in your childhood and how you are navigating it right now as a parent.

We can all make our way into experiencing more ventral vagal, social engagement, awe, wonder, and play, and it's everything that we've been doing together. It's weaving a coherent narrative of our past and our present. It's casting our vision into the future and showing up every day in service to the intention that you have for who you want to be. It's not wanting to be someone else because you hate yourself, it's having this pull. A flower doesn't bloom because hates itself, it's blooming because it has no other choice except for following its authenticity and its purpose. I believe that a hundred percent of us have a purpose of being kind, being in love, being connected, being good, full hearted, awe, wonder, magic, mystery, venture, exploration, and discovery. We all have different ways of expressing and enjoying these qualities. We're going to go through the workbook and learn the 12 different play languages.

So each of you, as a parent, if you're quite disconnected from that inner child, inner playful, inner joy space, that's okay. Learning what brought you joy in your childhood, and many clients I've worked with can't remember their childhood, they don't know what joy feels like. Even remembering being a kid is remembering pain, heartbreak, sorrow, and fear. So tuning into the inner child isn't helpful for some people in order to reclaim joy in their body. We're going to meet you where you're at and we're going to find what brings you joy. What does joy feel like in your body? And the most beautiful destiny that we are longing to arrive at in joy is the stillness.



It's being able to be on the floor with your children, with chaos everywhere, messes everywhere, dishes, and a bazillion things on your list, and to be in a grounded trust. To be able to look around and think, "This is crazy. How lucky am I to be here? This is absolutely a wild mayhem, and it's temporary. I can see myself in 20 years looking back at this time and thinking, I wish I would have sat down on the floor and played more. I wish I would've let the laundry go for a day and slumped down into the couch and watched a show with my child, and asked them questions and entered their world, and met my child in their joy". And of course, you're an adult. You have responsibilities. You need to cook, you need to clean. So we're not telling you to abandon everything and just play all day with your children, which many people will rebuttal against me saying play is a gift and an honor.

And you get to have boundaries in your play. You get to have authenticity and say, "I'm not feeling it right now. I really don't want to play with you right now. I'm tired. I'm not feeling well. I've got work to do". We're learning how to affirm our children and to prevent the reception and the perception of rejection when we give our child a "no". So practicing being able to get down and look at your baby, however old they are, scoop them up in your arms, put a hand on their shoulder and say, "Oh, I can't wait to connect with you and play this game and I'm not available right now. I will be available in about 20 minutes or two hours", depending on the child and their ability to conceptualize time, "And I can't wait to play with you then". So we're wanting to be able to embrace that you matter, you have needs, you have obligations, you have responsibilities, you get to communicate these things, and having realistic expectations based on your child's development. Just because they're eight doesn't mean that they "should" be able to play on their own. There's no should's, it's all about the security of their attachment. If your friend's kid is able to play independently and they're only two years old, but your five-year-old is still needing you to play every game, first of all, being in a place of acceptance and curiosity, and if independent play for your child is a goal, we're wanting to first look at you and the security of your attachment. This is the space for a coach to really support you through so you can get to a place of balance and equilibrium, and your child can feel safe enough in the security of your attachment. Thus, they feel safe in their body to access imagination, to access play, and they will naturally go into independence. And neurodiversity is real. Some of our children don't have imagination. They don't see the world in lots and lots of colors. They see it in very linear, black and white, their emotional communication and experience is different. So one person's way of playing and one child's way of playing is going to be very, very different. This whole practice is being aware of your authenticity of joy in play, your child's authenticity of joy in play, and learning how to navigate the in-between.



Parenting is about understanding how to be in intimacy with another person while being in sovereignty and security of yourself, and allowing the other person to be themselves, and work together through communication, negotiation, experimentation, trial and error, mistakes, and forgiveness. I'm excited for you all to get into the workbook and move through the questions that we have for you to get the reflection going, to gain more connection of why it is that you struggle playing. Or how do you thrive in playing, what makes that possible for you, and everything in between. Then we're going into storytelling, which is so beautiful and fun, and it's a beloved practice of myself in my family. And of course, oral storytelling has been around since the dawn of time. That is how humans are oriented. We all want to be a part of a lineage and to be a part of something that is bigger than ourselves. We have gotten quite far away from storytelling in many family homes, and we rely mostly on the imagination of others through books and media. And there is absolutely nothing wrong with books or media. We love reading. We love shows. We love being involved in the beautiful artistry and contribution of incredible artists and authors from all over the world. It's a beautiful time to be a human and being able to be connected to the root of oral storytelling and how we can utilize it in our parenting, through healing stories for challenging behavior.

Being able to connect with your child heart to heart and eye to eye, as we say, and tell them stories that uniquely meet them where they're at, can be such a gift of empathy, of mindsight, of bringing your child's life alive through story, through magic, awe, wonder, and possibility. And you can create stories that meet a child and their experience and role play out the kinds of things that they are going through, and thinking and feeling that their brain and their body is not equipped enough to be able to understand, comprehend, and integrate. It's an incredible tool for processing any kind of overwhelm, trauma, or scary experience that your child has had, or that your family is going through. And it can be fun, it can be silly. We want to go after the giggles. We want to go after the laughter. Laughter, smiling, giggling and being able to be in that magic together is so beneficial for you, your child, and your family as far as connection, mental wellbeing, physiological wellbeing. It floods your body with oxytocin and dopamine. It's a natural high.

It's reiterating that security and safety that connection is the meaning of life. Relationships are the most important thing. And when our child believes that relationships are the most important thing about being a human and connection is their lifeblood, of course they're going to collaborate and contribute based on their developmental level. Because it is their instinctual drive to be a part of a belonging, to be part of a family.

We can nourish and nurture our connection with our children. You've been doing a lot of great work. We get to nourish and nurture the security of our attachment through playing, which is such a relief because, who's tired of emotional regulation. Just me? Or maybe you? I'd rather play. I'd rather get outside in nature and climb a rock or go swimming, or run around and be silly. My children and I love hide and seek. We love being ridiculous. I'll go to them and I say, "All right, what are we playing? Sign me up, I'm here." Giving your child special time every day, or at least once a week, especially if you have multiple children and one of them is feeling left out or they're not getting as much as the other, their cup is empty, they're lacking security. We can utilize special time to be with our child, follow their lead. And this is any age. So a two year old, you follow them, you zip your lips, you simply witness, you let them tell you what to do, and you don't complain about it. And you recognize that you are in service to the security of your attachment.

This could be a tween or a teen who's wanting to go out for ice cream and watch silly videos on YouTube and just laugh. Or Tik Tok is a thing apparently. I don't have one, but I'm kind of scared of Tik Tok. And how to laugh, what makes your child giggle? Do more of that! Prioritize laughing! I know my personal parenting mantra is the success of my parenting is how often we laugh. Are you laughing? One of my favorite games to play with my children is this: you look at each other and you try to laugh without smiling, which is so funny. I'm going to do it to myself while looking into this camera. [Rebecca laughing with a straight face]. It's just ridiculously funny! You're looking at each other and you're trying to laugh without smiling and you're trying to make the other person laugh, and my family and I are just weeping with tears. So find what makes you laugh and what makes you silly? And it can be work. It can be work to be able to return to that place of feeling safe enough in your body to surrender, to feel safe enough in your body to let go and just be seen.

To play is to be vulnerable, to really play and to be seen. We've all got playground wounds. Maybe you were told that your games were stupid when you were young, or that you're boring, or that you don't know how to do it right. Or maybe you were the last one picked on the volleyball team every time and so you believe that you're not a good teammate.

Nobody wants to play with you. We're just being aware of how we've been impacted based on our childhood and how it keeps us from our birthright of joy, playfulness, wonder, awe, and laughter. And let's prioritize giggling and laughing. Even smiling, even if you don't mean it just feels good. It's so healing for you. I do our bedtime routine smiling and my children are like, "Why do you look like that?" "Because I'm trying not to lose my mind, that is why I look like this. So for the 1,000,000th time, let's go brush your teeth. Let's do it." And so there's going to be times in your day that you know are hard for you. For many parents, it's bedtime.



That's when play is the last thing that you want to do, please don't tell me to play with my child at bedtime. And it's a muscle. It's going to potentially not feel very comfortable when you're first starting the practice of it. You'll have resistance. You'll have skepticism. You'll have your default pattern. You'll have every excuse possible, and it's because you're needing to develop trust with it.

So just starting with a smile. Last night my children were bouncing off the walls before bed, which is very normal for a lot of children. They need to get the excess energy out of their body. I know there's been a lot of people saying not to let your child get riled up because then they won't sleep, but it really just depends on your child's body and their temperament, and some kids do need to express a lot of pent up energy for them to find the safety in their body to fall asleep. And I felt very tired, and I thought to myself in that moment, "I have a choice here. I can get playful, speed this up and get to bed. Or I could sit over here and complain, whine, and be dedicated to dread and powerlessness, and have this take three more hours". And I didn't want to choose play honestly, I was having kind of a good time feeling like I'm the victim of that scenario. I have enough practice by now where I was able to activate my sympathetic nervous system to get me into social engagement, to make a choice to connect in play.

So it's a practice. It's a modality. It's an extreme sport, if you want to be honest. Parenting is an extreme sport and the more you laugh about it, the better. So challenge yourself to have special time with your child every day, challenge yourself to smile, giggle, and find the ridiculousness in being a parent. Even if you're going through something really, really painful and hard, how can you smile? How can you get your child to smile and to giggle? The book *Playful Parenting* by Lawrence Cohen is a beautiful resource. The book *Attachment Play* by Aletha Solter, I'm looking at it right over here, is a beautiful resource. The book *storytelling with children* by Nancy Melon is a beautiful resource. There's all kinds of opportunities for you to learn and grow. And most of all, not just focusing on the head of playful parenting, but really getting into the heart and the hands, and going out there and showing your child how silly and playful you are while being in balance with your adult and your responsibilities, and living in the "both and". So enjoy your workbook, enjoy your session with your coach. We'll see you next week for our final session as we're looking back in time over the last 12 weeks and reflecting on your personal transformation through the Jai Institute for Parenting, stepping in and reclaiming your sovereignty, your autonomy, and what is true about who you are, your capability, and your capacity as an empowered parent. I'll see you then. Until then, I expect a giggle, expect you to go giggle right now. Thank you.

